



ANGRY AND ISOLATED: Villagers of Sanjarpur feel demonised (left); students at the Jamiatur Rashad madrasa

Atankgarh—the terrorist town—provoking the caricatured citizens of Saraimir on the outskirts of Azamgarh to raise banners that read “Journalists and Rumourmongers Keep Away”.

Such warnings have not succeeded in keeping the sightseers of Islamic terrorism’s newly discovered “nursery” away. And there are enough sights and voices to sustain terror tourism. Disillusioned elders may drop inspirational names from history and culture to redeem the place from headlines. Remember the poets and seers, scholars and savants, before you condemn the entire town to your mental Gitmo. Think of Allama Shibli Nomani, the great Islamic scholar, before you say Abu Salem, one of the prominent sons of Azamgarh, now languishing in a Mumbai jail. (Today in Saraimir, you have to be content with

IN AZAMGARH, martyrdom can be booked in advance, and victimhood is a constant anticipation.

Salem’s brother sunbathing on a plastic chair in front of his shop of electrical goods.) Well, heritage and history are overshadowed by the sociology and theology of radical Islam.

The first shift as you approach the town in a sweltering afternoon is in alphabets and architecture. Hindi gives way to Arabic, and minarets of varying sizes are a recurrence. Signs of Western Union Money Transfer mark almost every turn in the dusty, dirty town where the only growing indus-